

ON TECHNIQUE

Modernism and medievalism

Many features of Satie's musical style were a reaction against the overblown Romanticism of the 19th century. He proposed an understated lightness and simplicity, which he achieved by deliberately avoiding techniques associated with emotional expression, such as harmonic progressions and development of themes. Instead, he returned to the cool austerity of medieval music, but with stark modern harmonies. Much of his music has a static, detached quality, with a dry wit that became a hallmark of his work. Its spare textures and repetition were an important influence on many subsequent composers, up to and including the Minimalists, such as Philip Glass.

Often referred to as the “Velvet Gentleman,” sporting a dapper gray frock coat and pince-nez, Erik Satie was a familiar figure in the cafés and cabarets of Paris at the turn of the 20th century. The image he cultivated was of the quintessential Parisian gentleman, showing little evidence of his highly unconventional ideas.

He was born Eric Alfred Leslie Satie in Honfleur, Normandy, in 1866, the elder son of Alfred Satie, a translator, and his Scottish wife, Jane Leslie. The family moved to Paris in 1870, but when Jane died two years later, Eric and his brother Conrad lived with their grandparents in Honfleur until 1878, when they rejoined their father in Paris.

Satie had a conventional middle-class education, which included music lessons, and was encouraged by his new stepmother, a piano teacher, to play and compose. His efforts